

Information through e-mail is more elaborate—it includes reports of humidity, solar radiation, air temperature, precipitation, leaf wetness, and dew point.

Farmers use disease forecasts to plan a preventive spray schedule. This drastically reduces crop damage due to insects and diseases. This is also good for the environment, as it means fewer pesticide residues in the crop. And now, given the growing consumer awareness of pesticide residues and the premium that consumers are willing to pay for farm produce with low-level residues, farmers can demand better prices in the domestic as well as export markets.

Agrocom also offers bulk purchase of SMS credits, which are then distributed to farming organisations and KVKs. Agro universities and KVKs buy these services so that they can interact with the farmers and forward relevant information, they depend on government grants for this.

Agrocom also supports infrastructure-building projects, providing consultancy and support to farming organisations that want to install automated weather stations for purposes of farm-level disease forecasting, weather record validation for weather insurance, and weather forecasts for decision support. Agrocom's predictions have been shown to have an accuracy level of 80 to 90 per cent, based on random surveys.

Mobile At Sea

The M. S. Swaminathan Research Foundation (MSSRF), a Chennai-based research body that works on agricultural and rural development as a part of community service, has been providing weather information to a fishing village called Veerampattinam, and a neighbouring village, Nallavadu, since 1992—and has been saving fishermen's lives. But since the announcement is through a public address system at 3 AM (when fishermen venture out) there is no way to communicate sudden changes in weather when the fishermen are out at sea. MSSRF therefore developed a simple solution to address the issue: use the cell phone.

QUALCOMM, a pioneer in CDMA communication technology, and actively involved in vari-



“Once we complete the trial phase, we will work with our ecosystem partners to identify the business opportunities and financials”

Parag Kar
Senior Director
Government Affairs
QUALCOMM India



ous social projects the world over, partnered with MSSRF and developed a user-friendly mobile application, called Fisher Friend. It has a user-friendly interface and provides vital, real-time information to fishing communities—anytime, anywhere—at the press of a button.

The application, developed by Indore-based Astute Systems Technology, on the BREW (Binary Runtime Environment for Wireless) platform—QUALCOMM's open solution for wireless applications development and device configuration—allows users to access information through an interactive menu. It allows fishermen to know if it is the right time to venture out to sea; it provides vital updates like the location of fishing shoals, risks, and fish trade information in the local language (Tamil at present). The information channels the energy of fishermen in the right direction, optimising time and fuel.

Satellite images are the basis for the information regarding weather and fish concentration; it is accumulated in a centrally-located server at MSSRF. This information is then analysed by MSSRF, and sophisticated technical information like sea wave heights is processed to make it usable. The processed data is sent to Astute to be encoded for the BREW platform. The project is now in the trial phase, and involves 10 fishermen using Tata Teleservices in Veerampattinam. Created in Tamil, the application will be first rolled out in places where Tamil is understood.

The service is available in the 10 to 15 kilometre range within domestic waters, which covers about 80 per cent of fishermen's requirements. Extending this limit is not possible because regulations do not currently permit mobile communication in international waters.

Parag Kar, senior director, Government Affairs, QUALCOMM India and SAARC, says, “Pricing for the service at the moment has not been decided. Feedback from the fishermen is being collected to enhance the application in terms of user-friendliness and how far it is reflective of the needs of the fishing community. We have finished with phase zero (of four) and we are in phase one, which will be completed by the end of 2007.” Going by media reports, the application is likely to be perfected by November of this year, and will be deployed on about 100 phones across the coast. It is also reported that QUALCOMM is working on incorporating GPS capabilities into the phones so the exact location of the phone can be tracked, and so that rescue becomes easier in the case of a disaster.

Why Not?

The technology is all there, but only a few rural entrepreneurs take it to a stage where those as yet unempowered by that technology can use it. We must not forget that technology is not for and by the middle class alone. If we can have IT parks, we can have services such as those we've discussed rolled out all over the country... and that would benefit not just the farmer and the fisherman; we would all benefit in return—individually and as a nation. Certain ideas—such as “the illiterate cannot use technology”—must be wiped out. After all, tech enhances life, wherever, whoever. ☑

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Fishermen included in the trial phase of QUALCOMM's service using the Fisher Friend application while out at sea